

There were no microchips in those days and the electrical components generated so much heat it took tons of AC being forced through the cabinets of the machines to keep them cool. It was my job, as well as others to keep all of this equipment running. These computers were used for various administrative purposes such as payroll, etc. but were heavily used for scientific purposes such as missile design, etc. One of these larger computers was used by NORAD to track missiles, objects in space, etc. A very powerful large scale scientific digital computer at the time. Eventually I was promoted and put in charge of a similar computer site at Chrysler Missile in Warren, Michigan. I later moved back to California to work at a new company trying to use small computers that had become obsolete for their original design, for use as a payroll system for small manufacturing shops. The computers were old design and needed lots of AC to stay cool. The customers would not spend the money for the required AC so the machines would overheat and fail. The CEO asked me to pad the amount of time I spent at a customer's site so he could bill the customer for more time than I spent there. I said no and began my plan to exit the company. Remember fate being right around the corner? Around that same time, I received a call from a V.P. from Philco asking if I would consider returning to Philco. When I asked why, he related Philco had serious problems at the Aeronutronic site. The person in charge was unable to get the situation under control. He wanted me to come back to fix the problems, but I would need to report to the person who was unable to fix the problems. A rather awkward position. In that day computers required 24-hour coverage, so the technicians were rotated through three 3 shifts: 8 am to 4 pm, 4 pm to midnight, and midnight to 8 am. By this time, I had decided to go to college full time, but I would still need to have a part time job. I saw an opportunity, so I told the V.P. I would get them out of trouble if they met my conditions. I would only work the 4 pm to midnight shift, not rotating shifts. The person in charge did not rotate, but always worked 8 am to 4 pm. We could pretend the other person was in charge, and I could pretend I did not report to him if he left work before 4 pm and I came in at 4 pm. Something like two ships passing in the dark. The response was, "WE CANNOT DO THAT!" My response was "OK, GOOD LUCK. THANKS FOR CONSIDERING ME." Two days later, "OK! How soon can you report?" I ended up with a full-time job with benefits while I would be going to college. In about two weeks I had all of the problems resolved. I knew at that point, from my past experience, I could keep everything purring along, barring any major equipment failure, by doing two hours of preventative maintenance each shift. That left me 6 hours to study and do my homework assignments. Greatest job ever for going to school!! Just as I was to begin my final year at Long Beach State, Aeronutronic decided to discontinue using the larger computer. They were going to continue using the smaller computer I had installed when I first came to that site years ago. Philco told me I would be terminated, and the in-charge person would remain until the smaller computer was to be discontinued. Most of the problems I had been brought back to resolve were associated with the smaller computer system. DAH!